Heights of Winter Rogaine 2013: Controller's report

Over 550 people took part in the 2013 Heights of Winter Rogaine, a record number in its 16 year history. The increase in numbers was aided by the introduction of a 2.5-hour rogaine to the existing 6-hour and 10-hour events, but nevertheless the numbers in the longer two events would have been a record anyway. With the "Woodbury Wander" – as we named this year's event – being the first rogaine held in South Canterbury, Woodbury resident and orienteer, Mike Harding, aimed the 2.5 at the local community and Geraldine High School.

Traditionally the longer Heights of Winter format has been 12-hour rather than 10. However, when PAPO was asked to shift the date from the near full-moon of 22 June because of a clash with the inaugural Australasian Rogaining Championships, the new date ended up on a no moon. Given the rugged nature of much of the terrain including bush-filled streams with gorge sections, I decided that the period of darkness should be shortened especially for the safety of less experienced teams. However, another aspect of the 10-hour format that is worth bearing in mind is that it allows the local community group (in this case Geraldine High School PTA) to finish up around 10 pm rather than midnight.

While acknowledging Penny Wright and her willing on-the-day helpers, this year's event was only possible because of the dedication of a handful of enthusiasts:

- Mike Harding first proposed the area and then did the land-owner liaison, assisted with planning, pre-event organisation and obtaining heaps of publicity not only in the local community but also in the Timaru Herald.
- Martin Etherington, not content with his commitments as PAPO treasurer, put his hand up for a first try as a rogaine planner, handled entries and finances, pre-event organisation and results. That no teams scored all controls but that all controls were visited is something Martin can take much satisfaction from.
- Dave Laurie also came on board as our cartographer as well as assisting with planning and pre-event organisation.

Mike and Janet also provided a home away from home for the planning crew and, on the event weekend, besides their three sons, hosted something like 14 organisers and competitors. And they never lost their smiles.

Finally a big thank you to the control collectors on the Sunday who helped our core group get all but two in that day: Val Rogers, Richard English, Steve and Andrew Petty, Jac and Lesley Woudberg and Warren & Mrs McKie.

~ Stuart Payne